

and perceptions of readiness for leadership, reducing retention of top female talent.

Purushothaman emphasises that addressing this requires both structural and cultural change. Transparent pay frameworks, consistent promotion criteria, and leaders who consciously sponsor and amplify women's visibility are steps that can make a difference.

"Achieving equity requires both personal agency and organisational accountability. I teach women to know their worth, prepare thoroughly, and leverage networks and mentors to navigate cultural and systemic dynamics effectively. I often hear from mid-career Indian women that a sponsor who highlights their work can be the difference between promotion and being overlooked," she notes.

Shreya Krishnan, Managing Director, India at the nonprofit AnitaB.org India, emphasises that pay disparity in corporate India is deeply nuanced and pervasive.

"It's not a personal view; it's a fact-based understanding. Very few organisations actually achieve meaningful pay parity. Otherwise, differences range from 60% and upwards for the same job, skill set, and education," she says.

Pay parity is also affected by motherhood. For every child, a man gains 7–9% of his salary (a global data point), while a woman loses 5–7% of her salary, she says. Additionally, women often outperform male peers academically but face challenges in interviews and placements, perpetuating disparities up the ladder.

Krishnan highlights perception and confidence as critical factors. "Women are often not perceived as strong negotiators, even though they can be exceptional. Societal conditioning influences confidence. Men apply for roles even if they meet 30–40% of the criteria,

Women in Power

18.5%

SHARE OF WOMEN BOARD MEMBERS AT LISTED INDIAN COMPANIES

11%

OF THEM ARE EXECUTIVE DIRECTORS (VS 35% MEN)

14%

SHARE OF WOMEN IN NEW CXO APPOINTMENTS IN H1 2025, DOWN FROM 20% IN 2024, DESPITE A 25% RISE IN ABSOLUTE NUMBERS

62%

SHARE OF CHROs IN WOMEN CXO APPOINTMENTS IN H1 2025, DOWN FROM 77% IN H1 2024

while women apply only if they meet 90–100%."

The core reason the gender pay gap persists at mid-senior levels, she notes, is mindset. Women often undervalue themselves, while men overvalue themselves, affecting pay outcomes. Confidence and self-belief often determine career progression.

Policy interventions alone cannot fully address the gap. "Yes, pay frameworks and advocacy are essential, but the change has to start with collective mindset shifts. When women recognise and project their value internally and externally, it influences compensation outcomes," she says.

Industry experts warn the real cost of unequal pay goes beyond salaries. Retention suffers, recruitment and onboarding costs rise, innovation takes a hit, psychological safety erodes, and engagement declines, often resulting in quiet quitting.

WHAT WOMEN CAN DO, BEYOND NEGOTIATION

The idea that women simply "don't negotiate enough" is partly a myth.

While negotiation plays a role, the real gap runs deeper, rooted in structural and behavioural biases.

"Studies show that even when women ask for more, they are often rewarded less than men, and assertive behaviour can be judged

more harshly. Data shows men tend to receive higher initial offers and better outcomes when they negotiate, women don't."

In India, negotiation can also be culturally tricky for women, as assertive requests are sometimes perceived as pushy. That's why negotiation works best when paired with visibility, strategic advocacy, and sponsorship. Planning career moves thoughtfully and advocating for accommodations, such as flexible schedules or reintegration support, can help